

SIPHO AND SIPHOKAZI

Written by

The Panelwise team

Self-written sample screenplay for Panelwise, with deliberately awkward
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FADE IN:

1 EXT. HARBOUR -- DAWN 1

A small fishing harbour on a wild coast. Grey water, grey sky, a single row of forty-year-old wooden fishing-boats knocking against a concrete jetty.

On the jetty, a salt-and-pepper-bearded fisherman in a sea-green oilskin coils a rope into a perfect figure-of-eight. This is SIPHO (50s).

Gulls wheel. A dog trots past with a fish-head in its mouth. Siphos do not look up.

2 INT. BAIT SHOP 2

A tin-roofed shack that smells of salt and diesel. Buckets of sardines on ice. A calendar from nineteen-ninety-something curls on the wall.

SIPHOKAZI (17), in a school jersey two sizes too big, counts coins onto the counter. MAMA THEMBI (60s), the shop's owner, watches her over half-moon glasses.

MAMA THEMBI
Your uncle knows you're here?

SIPHOKAZI
My uncle knows everything. He just doesn't say it.

MAMA THEMBI
(sliding a bucket across
the counter, then leaning
in close so nobody else
will hear)
Kazi. Is it true, what they say?
The university letter came?

Siphokazi nods. She cannot stop the smile.

SIPHOKAZI
Cape Town. Marine science. I start
in February.

MAMA THEMBI
And Siphos?

SIPHOKAZI
I haven't told him yet.

SMASH CUT TO:

3 INT./EXT. SIPHO'S BAKKIE - MOVING - DAY

3

An old white pick-up truck rattles down a dirt road toward the sea. Siphokazi rides beside him with the bucket of sardines between her feet and a battered notebook on her knees: the TIDE BOOK.

SIPHO
You're reading your grandmother's
tide book again.

SIPHOKAZI
She wrote down every tide for
thirty-one years. Every storm.
Every good catch.

SIPHO
She wrote down every time I was
late for supper.

Siphokazi laughs. Siphokazi almost smiles. The bakkie hits a pothole and the sardines slosh.

SIPHO (CONT'D)
Kazi. Whatever you're not telling
me, tell me on the boat.

4A EXT. OPEN SEA - DAY

4A

The fishing boat NOMSA, blue paint peeling, rides long swells a mile offshore. Siphokazi hauls a line hand over hand. Siphokazi baits hooks with quick, practised fingers.

On the horizon, a bruise-coloured bank of cloud is building, fast.

Neither of them sees it yet.

4B INT. BOAT CABIN - CONTINUOUS

4B

A cramped wheelhouse. A compass, a crackling VHF RADIO, a photograph of an old woman taped above the wheel.

The radio bursts into life.

COASTGUARD (V.O.)
All vessels, all vessels. Gale
warning for the coast from Hole in
the Wall to the river mouth. Return
to harbour immediately.

Siphokazi is at the wheel in a heartbeat. Siphokazi scrambles in behind him.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

SIPHOKAZI

The tide's turning. If we go straight in over the bar now, we'll hit it on the ebb.

SIPHO

I have crossed that bar a thousand times.

SIPHOKAZI

Not at half-past-four on a spring ebb in the teeth of a south-westerly. Gogo wrote it down. Look.

She holds the tide book open under his nose. He does not look.

Outside, a wave slaps over the bow. A coil of rope slides toward the open stern.

SIPHOKAZI

NO! THE ROPE!

She lunges out of the cabin.

5 EXT. OPEN SEA - CONTINUOUS

5

Rain comes sideways. Siphokazi grabs the rope just before it goes over and hauls it back, soaked to the skin.

Sipho brings the boat around, away from the harbour mouth, heading north along the coast.

6 INT. BOAT CABIN - CONTINUOUS

6

Siphokazi stumbles back in, dripping. Sipho does not take his eyes off the water.

SIPHO

(barely audible over the storm, and not quite looking at her)

Where does the book say?

SIPHOKAZI

The cove at Mngazana. Gogo sheltered there in eighty-seven.

SIPHO

Then read me the way in. Every word.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MATCH CUT TO:

7 EXT. MNGAZANA COVE - NIGHT 7

A sheltered bay under dark cliffs. The storm roars out at sea, but here the water is almost still.

The Nomsa sits at anchor, a single lamp swinging in her wheelhouse.

No one speaks. The rain eases. One by one, stars come out over the cliffs.

8 INT. BOAT CABIN - NIGHT 8

Lamplight. Uncle and niece sit shoulder to shoulder on the floor, wrapped in one blanket, sharing a flask of sweet tea.

SIPHO

When were you going to tell me?

SIPHOKAZI

(startled)

Tell you what?

SIPHO

Mama Thembi has a loud voice and a small shop.

A long pause. Siphokazi looks down at the tide book.

SIPHOKAZI

I start in February. Marine science. I'm going to study all of this. The tides and the storms and the fish. Properly. Not just in a notebook.

SIPHO

Your grandmother did it properly. In a notebook.

SIPHOKAZI

I know.

He takes the tide book from her, gently. He turns to the last page with writing on it. Then to the first empty page after it. He hands it back, and a pencil.

SIPHO

Then you had better keep writing.

9 INT. SIPHO'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT 9

Weeks later. A small kitchen, a paraffin lamp. A packed suitcase stands by the door.

On the table, the tide book lies open beside a university prospectus. The newest entry in the book is in a young, neat hand.

Nobody is in the room. The lamp flickers.

10 EXT. HARBOUR -- DAWN 10

The same grey water. The same row of boats. Sipho coils a rope into a perfect figure-of-eight.

He looks up at the horizon for a long moment. Then, from the pocket of his oilskin, he takes out a new notebook and a pencil, and writes the date.

CUT TO BLACK.